NATIONAL ASSEMBLY 7TH PARLIAMENT

PARLIAMENTATRY STANDING COMMITTEE ON HUMAN RESOURCES AND COMMUNITY DEVELOPMENT

REPORT OF THE MOTION ON ESTABLISHING SPECIAL SCHOOLS IN THE KAVANGO EAST AND KAVANGO WEST REGIONS

REPORT NO. 4 OF 2025

TABLE OF CONTENTS

MANDATE OF THE COMMITTEE iii
COMPOSITION OF THE COMMITTEE iv
1. INTRODUCTION 1
2. TERMS OF REFERENCE (TOR) 1
3. METHODOLOGY 1
4. PURPOSE OF THE REPORT 2
5. CONSULTATIVE MEETINGS 2
5.1. Ministry of Education, Arts and Culture 2
5.2 Kavango West Region 3
5.3 Kavango East Region 4
5.4 University of Namibia (UNAM) 5
5.5 Namibia National Students Organisation (NANSO) 5
5.6 Student Representative Councils (SRC) 5
5.7 Namibia National Teachers Organization (NANTU) 5
6. CHALLENGES 5
7. FINDINGS 6
8. CONCLUSION 7
9. RECOMMENDATIONS 7
CHAIRPERSON'S SIGNATURE 8

MANDATE OF THE COMMITTEE

The mandate of the Committee is derived from Article 59 of the Namibian Constitution as well as Rule 74 (1) of the Standing Rules and Orders and Internal Arrangements of the National Assembly. The Committee must consider, examine and inquire on any matter it deems relevant about the following category of affairs, which includes, among others;

- Higher Education, Training and Innovation
- Education, Arts and Culture
- Urban and Rural Development
- Sport, Youth and National Service
- Labour, Industrial Relations and Employment Creation

and may for that purpose consult and liaise with relevant institutions;

a) liaise with NGOs, Agencies and Institutions to enquire and monitor programmes that are aimed at uplifting the social and economic conditions of communities;
b) monitor and enquire into all matters related to human resource development;
c) monitor and enquire into all matters related to the development of both rural and urban communities;
d) monitor and enquire into all matters related to the needs of the youth;
e) promote harmonious industrial relations in Namibia;
f) review and advise the National Assembly on the housing needs of the people;
g) enquire into and monitor international protocols, conventions and agreements that may affect the county's human resources and community development and where necessary make recommendations to the Assembly; and
h) perform other functions, tasks, and duties relating to Parliamentary supervision of such Offices, Ministries, Agencies or State-Owned Enterprises and Parastatals as may be prescribed by the Assembly or in terms of an Act of Parliament.

COMPOSITION OF THE COMMITTEE

Hon. Non Katjingisiua, MP	Hon. Elifas Dingara, MP
Committee Chairperson	**Deputy Chairperson**
Hon. Tjekero Tweya, MP	Hon. Agnes Mpingana Kafula, MP
Hon. Bertha Dinyando, MP	Hon. Elma Dienda, MP
Hon. Winnie Rauha Moongo, MP	Hon. Yvette Araes, MP
Hon. Maximalliant Katjimune, MP	Hon. Johanna Kandjimi, MP
Hon. Gotthard Kandume, MP	Hon. Annakletha Sikerete
Hon. Utaara Mootu, MP	Hon. Maria Kamutali, MP
Hon. Dr. Becky Ndjoze-Ojo, MP	Hon. Herlinde Lucia Tjiveze, MP
Hon. Natangwe Ithete, MP	Hon. Diederik Vries, MP
Hon. Ephraim Nekongo, MP	Hon. Hidipo Hamata, MP
Hon. Longinus Iipumbu, MP	Hon. Bernadus Swartbooi, MP
Hon. Agnes Tjiramba, MP	Hon. Loide Iipinge, MP
Hon. Katrina Benz, MP	Hon. Aina Hanganeni Kodi, MP

ACRONYMS

NANSO	-	Namibia National Students Organisation
NANTU	-	Namibia National Teachers Union
NAOPE	-	Namibia Organization of Parents in Education
SRC	-	Students Representative Council
SDG	-	Sustainable Development Goals
TOR	-	Terms of Reference
UNAM	-	University of Namibia

1. INTRODUCTION

1.1. Education is one of the most complex and challenging tasks every society is faced with, and no simple solutions to the problems in education. In Namibia, the right to education is enshrined in Article 20 (1) and Article 95 of the Namibian Constitution, the Basic Education Act 2020 as well as under the Sustainable Development Goal 4 (SDG) on Quality Education.

1.2. Vision 2030 expressly stated that Namibia should develop a knowledge-based society. This knowledge-based society requires people who are healthy, well educated, skilled, pro-active, with a broad range of abilities.

1.3. Therefore, the challenges facing children with learning difficulties are not only peculiar to one or two regions of Namibia, but it is a problem affecting the whole country.

1.4. In 2023, the Motion calling for the establishment of Special Schools in the Kavango East and Kavango West Regions was tabled in the House and subsequently referred to the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Human Resources and Community Development for further scrutiny and report back to the Assembly.

2. TERMS OF REFERENCE (TOR)

The objectives of the Motion were to look into the following aspects;

2.1. That the Ministry of Education, Arts and Culture present an Action Plan that includes the construction of Special Schools in the two Kavango Regions, and

2.2. Whether the Action Plan is integrated in the current National Development Plan and other government developmental programmes.

3. METHODOLOGY

The Committee held a consultative meeting with the Ministry of Education, Arts and Culture in Windhoek and undertook regional consultations with relevant stakeholders in the two Kavango Regions, such as:

3.1. Directorates of Education, Arts and Culture;

3.2. School Boards;

3.3. Namibia National Teachers Union (NANTU);

3.4. Namibia National Students' Organization (NANSO);

3.5. Student Representative Councils (SRC)

3.6. Namibia Organization of Parents in Education (NAOPE);

4. PURPOSE OF THE REPORT

The purpose of this report is to submit the Committee's findings and recommendations to the Assembly for discussion and adoption.

5. CONSULTATIVE MEETINGS

5.1. Ministry of Education, Arts and Culture

a) The Ministry of Education, Arts and Culture has the mandate to deliver on the desired outcomes of Vision 2030, that is, to build a knowledge-based society by the year 2030. This is in addition to the provision of the Constitution of Namibia and other international instruments acceded to by Namibia such as the Sustainable Development Goals (SDG).

b) The Mission of the Ministry is to provide accessible, equitable and inclusive quality education for a tolerant, skilled, productive and competitive nation and promote and preserve arts, culture for nationhood and national pride.

c) The Ministry stated that the process of establishing any school is normally on the initiative of individual regions as it is based on the identified need after a feasibility study was conducted. Once the evidence of constructing a school is available and an assessment done to verify the need for a school, it is only when the project will be registered to secure funding.

d) The Ministry has introduced Resource Units and Inclusive Schools where learners are taught alongside their peers who are without disabilities and provided with the needed assistance and equipment to access the curriculum. Learning Support Classes are also provided to learners with an educational backlog until they overcome the backlog to be moved back to the mainstream. Additionally, Basic Pre-Vocational Skills Course is offered to those who seem not to progress in the academic stream.

e) Currently, the Ministry have 12 Resource Schools in Khomas and Oshana Regions, respectively, and 12 Resource Units: Hardap Region = 1, Erongo Region = 2, Zambezi Region = 2, Ohangwena Region = 1, Oshana Region = 1, Kavango East = 4, and Kunene Region = 1.

f) In Kavango East Region, the Resource Units for learners with visual and intellectual impairment are situated at Dr. Romanus Kampungu Senior Secondary

School, while the Resource Unit for Deaf learners is at the Andreas Kandjimi Primary School. Inclusive Education is being practiced both at Andreas Kandjimi Primary School and Maria Mwengere Senior Secondary School, mainly for the deaf learners.

g) In Kavango West Region, there is a learning support unit at Leevi Hakusembe Senior Secondary School and offers a 2-year Basic Pre-Vocational Skills Course. Another unit for learners with learning difficulties is being established at Kahenge Combined School, and a request was also made to upgrade the hostel facilities to accommodate physically impaired learners. This project is already budgeted to the amount of N$5 000 000.00.

h) The Ministry said that other learning support classes are largely dependent on the need, the availability of classrooms and teachers qualified to offer learning support. However, the Ministry is faced with the dire need of funds for the renovation of schools and units to be made more accessible to the learners. There is also a need for workshops with the latest equipment to equip learners for the job market after completing the Basic Pre-Vocational Skills Course.

i) Furthermore, the ministry informed the Committee that they are aware that there are still many disabled children in the country who are unaccounted for and not brought to their facilities. The absence of these statistics made it difficult to do proper planning for the required support.

j) The ministry has a plan to build one Special School in its current implementation plan, but the location of such facility is not yet decided.

5.2 Kavango West Region

a) The Directorate of Education informed the Committee that the needs are high for the learners who need special support. They said learners are put in one group irrespective of their social level or groupings. It is a challenge, but because of inclusive education, it is being done. It is an absurd situation for those learners who need special attention. They said that most buildings, including hostels, are not disability friendly and called for the facilities to be evenly distributed throughout the region.

b) The Region has a special unit at Kahenge Combined School for learners having various learning difficulties, among others, intellectual disabilities, physical disabilities, blindness, and deafness. Due to lack of facilities in the region, some

learners are being transported by the Directorate of Education daily to other schools in the Kavango East Region such as Dr. Romanus Kampungu Senior Secondary School, Maria Mwengere Senior Secondary School and Andreas Kandjimi Primary School. This is a costly exercise for the Directorate of Education. Additionally, Leevi Hakusembe Senior School has a basic pre-vocational centre to assist learners with disability, especially those who cannot fit in the mainstream schools.

c) The Directorate said they have plans to cater for disabled learners, but due to budgetary constraints, no implementation is being done. However, some schools and teachers raised concerns that special schools are not taken seriously or given the attention they deserve, or perhaps they are forgotten. They gave an example whereby Reading and Writing are prerequisites for every learner. But these learners are facing difficulties especially when it comes to promotions because the policy states that a learner can only repeat a grade once.

d) The Directorate fully support the establishment of a special school in the region, saying that such schools should be built according to the learners' challenges, as they cannot all be accommodated in one school. This will also assist for schools to get teachers with specific skills or expertise, because currently most of the teachers at mainstream schools have no such skills.

5.3 Kavango East Region

a) The Directorate of Education, though it has acknowledged the Sector Policy on Inclusive Education, welcomed the need for establishing special schools and facilities in the region. This sentiment was echoed by other stakeholders who suggested that special schools should not be incorporated or combined with normal or mainstream schools. This is because special schools need special teachers, infrastructure and equipment.

b) The Directorate highlighted that teachers in the mainstream schools are not equipped to handle learners with different abilities and in the process might neglect the learners with special needs. Initially, Resource Units were only limited to visually impaired, hearing impaired and learners who are physically challenged, but not other disabilities.

c) The directorate said they submitted to the Head Office the budget plan to cater for the challenges they are facing, but no response was received at the time of the visit. They said, another challenge they are facing was that the region also accommodates

learners with limited abilities from other regions such as the Kavango West Region and the Zambezi Region, respectively. In 2024, the number of special learners enrolled in Resource Units stood at 317.

5.4 University of Namibia (UNAM)

a) UNAM indicated that they are already offering courses or classes to teachers on how to work with learners with disabilities at their Khomasdal campus in Windhoek. However, not all campuses offer these classes due to lack of capacity.

5.5 Namibia National Students Organisation (NANSO)

a) NANSO said that the few mainstream schools that are in the regions are not enough to accommodate all learners with special needs, and not much attention is given to these learners. Many children are still stung at home.

b) Most, if not all, schools in the region have no facilities such as toilets and classrooms for the disabled, and this has to do with people doing planning for infrastructures.

5.6 Student Representative Councils (SRC)

a) The SRC thought that special schools need special teachers who have the expertise to handle both the physical and psychological disability of learners. They proposed that if no new facilities are built, at least each school should have a special unit.

5.7 Namibia National Teachers Organization (NANTU)

a) NANTU strongly supports the establishment of special schools in the regions since learners with learning difficulties are too many in the regions. Such schools are needed to cater for all learners, both in urban and rural schools.

b) Special schools should come with their own special principals, teachers, resources, hostels and other infrastructures required, and they should not be incorporated or combined with mainstream schools.

6. CHALLENGES

6.1. Shortage or lack of qualified teachers as teachers in the mainstream schools are not specialized in teaching and handling learners with various handicaps such as physical or mental condition. Some learners reportedly have severe conditions;

6.2. Principals and teachers experience difficulties in monitoring the activities of learners since they are not fully capacitated;

6.3. Current resource centres in the regions are normally to offer learning support, and these classrooms are not appropriate and have limited capacity to accommodate many learners with different disabilities;

6.4. Repetition of the same grade for years and having different age groups in one class;

6.5. Expensive programs as they require sophisticated teaching and learning materials;

6.6. The number of learners increases annually and they cannot cope in mainstream schools after integration;

6.7. Not enough hostel facilities to accommodate all, and they fall victim to abuse and crime on the way to school or home;

6.8. Bullying of learners in the mainstream schools is rife;

6.9. Lack of sufficient budget and financial support is impacting the development of special schools in the regions.

7. FINDINGS

7.1. The Ministry of Education, Arts and Culture has a plan to build one special school in its current implementation plan, but the location is not yet identified;

7.2. No immediate plan to build special schools in the two Kavango Regions and other regions countrywide;

7.3. Many schools have no special units for learners with special educational needs and those which have such units are mostly overcrowded;

7.4. Resource Units that are available in the mainstream schools are not properly equipped and resourced to be more accessible for learners with different types of disabilities;

7.5. Lack of specialized or skilled teachers to teach and handle learners with different disabilities, nor equipped with knowledge or skills on the latest equipment being used for the basic pre-vocational skills course;

7.6. Lack of statistics on how many disabled children are not yet brought to the directorates of education or schools countrywide;

7.7. High dropout rate among learners with special educational needs;

7.8. Parents cannot afford to send learners to other regions for special schools as costs are too high;

7.9. Lack of hostel facilities to accommodate physically challenged or impaired learners.

8. CONCLUSION

8.1. Most stakeholders in the education sector in the two Kavango Regions showed their strong support for establishing special schools in their regions. They said that establishing such schools is long overdue, and it would assist the Ministry of Education, Arts and Culture to maintain a coordinated system with a highly effective learning environment. It will also assist teachers to focus on individual plans for every learner.

8.2. In many instances, learners with special needs are left out of opportunities afforded to their counterparts in the mainstream schools and this places them in a disadvantaged position. Hence, all stakeholders are implored to put hands together and provide the necessary support required to address the many challenges haunting these vulnerable learners of our society and to ensure that all learners irrespective of their social or economic standing have access to equitable and inclusive quality education.

9. RECOMMENDATIONS

9.1. Ministry of Education, Arts and Culture

a) The Ministry should build at least one multi-disciplinary special school in each region of Namibia;

b) Train multi-disciplinary teams and hire skilled teachers who can teach and handle learners with special education needs;

c) Secure funding and ensure that all current resource units/schools are renovated, upgraded and equipped with infrastructures that are disability user-friendly;

d) Increase grants and funding for learners with special needs;

e) Increase the number of special pre-vocational training centres for learners with special educational needs;

f) Conduct outreach programmes to determine how many more disabled children are in the regions and to identify where they are located;

9.2. University of Namibia (UNAM)

a) Secure funding to conduct research and extend the special training courses for teachers on how to handle and treat learners with special educational needs to all UNAM campuses in the country;

CHAIRPERSON'S SIGNATURE

Hon. Nono Katjingisiua, MP **Committee Chairperson**	04/03/2025 **Date**